

Velvet Contract

Grigor Yankov

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This is a work of fiction containing scenes intended for adult readers only (18+).

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Chapter 1

Chapter 1

The penthouse smells like money and no one lives here.

I notice it the moment I step out of the lift — that particular stillness of a room that’s been cleaned but not inhabited. The air is climate-controlled to exactly twenty-one degrees, filtered, scentless except for the faint chemical trace of marble sealant. Floor-to-ceiling windows run the length of the far wall, and the Mayfair light pours through them in a grey November sheet, turning everything inside into a photograph with the saturation turned down.

I’ve seen flats like this before. The spec is always the same: Italian marble, brushed brass fixtures, wide-plank oak flooring in a shade the supplier calls “driftwood” but no tree ever grew. Someone with a very large budget and absolutely no idea what to do with it hired a decorator who confused minimalism with personality. The result is a space that could belong to anyone, which means it belongs to no one.

I set my bag down by the door — Italian leather, five years old, the clasp Freja replaced last spring — and walk the perimeter. My heels click against the marble. The sound

carries in a way that tells me the rooms are empty in a way that goes beyond furniture.

“You’re early.”

The voice comes from the left. I turn.

He’s standing in the doorway to what I assume is the study, leaning against the frame with the kind of stillness that most people have to practice. He doesn’t do it for effect. I can tell because he was already positioned that way when I came in — he simply hasn’t moved.

“Mr Kincaid?”

“Dominic.” He steps forward. He’s tall, lean in the way of someone who was thin and then got disciplined about it. Dark hair, grey at the temples. A face that’s more interesting than handsome — sharp cheekbones, a mouth that looks like it doesn’t waste words. He’s wearing a navy suit, no tie, and the collar is open one button further than a man wears it in a boardroom. His shoes are John Lobb. I notice these things.

“Maya Delaney.” I don’t extend my hand first. I learned that from my first year in London — let the client set the terms of contact.

He does extend his. His grip is dry, brief, precise. He doesn’t try to prove anything with it.

“Eleanor said you’d want to survey before we talked,” he says. “I told her I’d stay out of your way.”

“And yet you’re here.”

“I live here.” A pause. “Technically.”

I almost smile at that. Technically. The penthouse is immaculate and unlived-in, and he knows I’ve noticed. There’s no coat thrown over a chair, no book open on the coffee table, no coffee cup in the sink. The kitchen counter is bare except for a single orchid in a ceramic pot — the kind an interior designer would place, not the person who lives there.

I walk toward the windows. The view is Grosvenor Square, the bare plane trees making skeletal fists against the grey sky. Below, a black cab turns onto Brook Street. The sound doesn't reach us up here. Nothing does.

"The light's good," I say. "Better than the photos Eleanor sent."

"The photos were taken at noon."

"Noon is the worst time for this flat. The western exposure means you get direct light for about four hours in the afternoon, and the rest of the day it's all reflected grey." I turn back to him. "You need to see a space in its worst light to understand what it needs."

He watches me. Not my body — my face, my hands, the way I move through the room. It's an assessing look, and I've had it from clients before. Usually it means they're deciding whether I'm worth the fee. Usually I don't care.

"The brief," I say. "Eleanor sent it. You want a full re-design. New layout, new materials, new everything. She said you've been here two years and haven't touched it."

"That's accurate."

"Why?"

He doesn't answer immediately. He walks to the kitchen — a sweep of Calacatta marble and matte-black cabinetry — and runs a glass of water from the tap. He doesn't offer me one. I appreciate that. The clients who offer you water are the ones who want you to feel grateful.

"I bought it finished," he says. "The previous owner had a designer. Very expensive. Very —" He pauses, searching for the word. "Safe."

"Safe."

"Nothing wrong with it. Nothing right with it either."

I turn that over. Most people who hire me have a vision,

even if they can't articulate it. They want the Kelly Wearstler apartment or the Soho House bedroom or something they saw in a magazine left on a plane. Dominic Kincaid is looking at me like he wants me to tell him what he wants.

"What don't you like about it?" I ask.

"The marble."

I wait.

"It's Calacatta," he says. "The previous designer chose it because it's expensive. It is expensive. It's also cold and busy and it makes the whole flat look like a hotel lobby."

He's right, and I'm surprised he knows the name. I look at the floor properly — white with dramatic grey veining, polished to a mirror finish. It's beautiful stone. It's also completely wrong for a residential space on the third floor of a Georgian building in Mayfair.

"You're not wrong," I say.

"I know."

"Portuguese limestone," I say. "Moleanos. Warm beige, fine grain, honed finish. It'll pull the light instead of fighting it."

"Show me."

I pull out my phone and open my sample folder — I keep high-res photos of every material I've ever specified. I find the Moleanos slab I used in the Notting Hill project last year and hand him the phone.

He studies it for longer than I expect. His eyes move the way mine do — across the grain, the colour variation, the way it catches light in a photograph.

"That," he says, handing the phone back. "That's the one."

"It's not the cheapest option."

"I didn't ask for the cheapest. I asked for the right one."

Something shifts in the room. Not the light — that's still grey, still flat. It's the air between us, the way he's looking at me now like I've passed a test I didn't know I was taking.

I walk further into the flat. The dining room is off the main space — a long room with a ten-seat table that looks like it's never been used for four. Beyond it, a hallway leads to the bedrooms. I can see the doorway to the master at the end, a sliver of king-size bed through the gap, white linen, perfectly made.

"How many bedrooms?" I ask, though I know from the plans.

"Four. I use one."

"And the others?"

"Guest room. Gym. Office."

"Do you work from home?"

"Sometimes."

I turn back to the main space. The ceiling is high — three and a half metres, original plasterwork around the edges, a modern chandelier in the centre that has no business being in a room with this much character. I make a mental note to replace it with something warmer. A Flos perhaps, or a Lindsey Adler if the budget allows.

"The layout works," I say. "Mostly. The kitchen should open more into the living area — the wall between them isn't structural. And the study —" I glance toward where I found him. "You don't use it."

"I use it."

"You use it the way someone uses a room they've been told to include. There's nothing personal in there. I could move your desk to the other wall, give you a view of the square instead of the hallway. You'd actually want to sit in it."

He's quiet for a moment. Then: "How do you know I don't already want to sit in it?"

"Because you were standing in the doorway when I arrived. People who love their studies sit in them."

The corner of his mouth moves. Not quite a smile — more like the acknowledgment that something was worth the silence it took to get there.

"You're direct," he says.

"You hired a designer who doesn't compromise. That's what Eleanor told me, isn't it? That's why you went with my firm."

"She said you were the best."

"She's my business partner. She's supposed to say that." I close my notebook. "I'll put together a concept board. Material samples, colour palette, furniture selections. We'll meet here next week — same time, if that works."

"I'll be here."

I walk back toward the lift, and he follows at a distance that's close enough to be polite and far enough that I'm aware of him without looking. At the door, I pause.

"The orchid," I say, glancing back at the kitchen counter. "Who waters it?"

"Eleanor."

"Get rid of it. If you want something living in here, get a plant that doesn't die when you forget it for a week. A *Zamioculcas*. A snake plant. Something that doesn't need you to perform."

He looks at the orchid like he's seeing it for the first time. Then he looks at me.

"Next week," he says.

I press the lift call button. The doors open immediately — Mayfair lifts are maintained like Swiss trains — and I step

inside. As the doors close, I catch his reflection in the polished steel. He's still standing where I left him, watching the space I was just standing in, and for a moment I see what he sees: a beautiful room with nothing to say.

The lift descends. My ears pop at the ground floor, and I step out into the lobby — marble floors, a concierge who knows better than to make small talk — and out onto the street. The November air hits me like a slap, cold and real after the climate-controlled stillness of the penthouse flat.

I walk toward the Tube. My hands are steady. My pulse is not.

It's the marble, I tell myself. The light. The challenge of a space that needs someone to tell it what it is.

It's not the way he looked at me like I was the first person to walk into his flat and tell him the truth.

I descend into Green Park station and the grey London afternoon swallows me whole.

Chapter 2

Chapter 2

The second time I see the penthouse, I bring three kilos of samples and Freja's advice: "Don't sleep with the client." She said it in the studio while I was pinning fabric swatches to the mood board, her Danish directness cutting through the conversation like a scissor through linen.

"I'm not going to sleep with the client."

"You didn't say that quickly enough."

She's wrong. I'm here to do a job. The Moleanos limestone samples arrived from the quarry on Tuesday, and I've arranged them on the dining table in a gradient from cream to warm grey, catching the late-morning light that finally, finally reaches this side of the building. I've also brought three options for the kitchen island, two brass finishes for the fixtures, and a velvet the colour of dried blood that I want to use on the reading chair by the window.

Dominic is already here. He's wearing a charcoal jumper today, sleeves pushed to the elbows, and there's a cup of coffee on the counter. His. He's learned to make his own, apparently. The orchid is gone.

“You replaced it,” I say, pointing to the empty counter with my chin.

“You told me to.”

“I suggested. I didn’t think you’d actually do it.”

He looks at the space where the orchid was. “I bought a plant. It’s in the study. The woman at the shop said it was unkillable.”

“What kind?”

“I don’t know the name. It’s green. It didn’t look like it needed much.”

“That’s almost the definition of a plant.”

He almost smiles again. That same micro-movement, like his face isn’t used to the expression and is testing it out cautiously.

I spread the limestone samples across the table. “Moleanos. I had them cut so you can see the honed finish in real size, not a catalogue photo. The left is straight from the saw, the right is after polishing. For the floors you want the honed. For the kitchen island, either works, but I’d lean honed. It’s more forgiving.”

He picks up the polished piece. Runs his thumb across the surface. “It’s warm.”

“It’s limestone. It’s supposed to be warm. That’s the whole point.”

“The Calacatta was cold.”

“The Calacatta was chosen to impress people who don’t have to live with it.” I set the sample down. “This is for you. Not for anyone walking through on a viewing tour.”

He looks at me over the sample. “You think I’d sell.”

“Everyone with money in Mayfair sells eventually. I’m designing for the living, not the leaving.”

Something passes across his face. Not offense. Recognition, maybe.

I move to the kitchen. “The island. I want to replace the Calacatta with the same Moleanos, but thicker — four centimetres instead of two. It needs to feel like it grew out of the floor, not like someone placed a slab on top of a cabinet.” I pull out the drawings I’ve been working on. “I’m opening this wall. The structural engineer confirmed it’s safe. You’ll get sightlines from the kitchen straight through to the living area. The flat will feel twice the size.”

He studies the drawings. His eyes move slowly. He doesn’t ask about cost. He doesn’t ask about timeline. He asks, “What happens to the light when the wall’s gone?”

“It changes everything. The living area gets the western sun in the afternoon, and the kitchen gets the morning light from the east. You’ll actually want to make breakfast.”

“I don’t make breakfast.”

“What do you do in the morning?”

“Coffee. The gym. Work.”

“That’s not a morning. That’s a routine.”

He hands the drawings back. “You’re not afraid to tell people they’re wrong.”

“I’m not telling you you’re wrong. I’m telling you your kitchen is wrong. There’s a difference.”

“Is there?”

“Yes. You I haven’t decided about yet.”

It comes out before I can filter it, and I feel the heat rise to my face. Not embarrassment exactly. Something adjacent to it.

He doesn’t react the way I expect. No smirk, no charm offensive. He just nods, like I’ve confirmed something he was already thinking.

“The study,” he says. “You said you’d move the desk.”

“Yes.”

“Show me.”

We walk down the hallway. The study is small, windowless, with built-in bookshelves that hold books arranged by colour. No one arranges books by colour unless they’ve never read them. I point to the far wall.

“Desk there. You face the window. The light comes in behind you, so you’re not working against glare. The shelves are to your left, which means you can reach them without turning. And when someone walks past the door, they see you, not the back of your head.”

“You’ve thought about this.”

“I’ve thought about every room in your flat. It’s my job to think about how you move through space.”

He stands where the desk would be. Looks toward where the window would be. “I can see the square from here.”

“You can see the square from here.”

He turns. We’re closer than I expected. The hallway is narrow, and he’s tall, and I can smell his cologne. Cedar and something sharper. Bergamot, maybe. It’s the kind of scent that doesn’t announce itself. It just arrives.

“My daughter,” he says. “She’s fourteen. Lives in New York with her mother. I see her twice a year if I’m lucky.”

I wasn’t expecting that. I don’t know what to do with the information, so I just hold it.

“That’s hard,” I say.

“It’s the cost of the life I chose. She was eight when we split. I thought I could maintain the relationship from here. I was wrong.”

“You could move closer. Open an office in New York.”

“I could.” He pauses. “I won’t. My work is here. And

she has a life there. Friends. A school she likes. Uprooting her for a father she sees twice a year would be for me, not for her.”

“That’s very clear-eyed.”

“Clear-eyed is what people call it when you make a choice they think is selfish but you know is the least damaging option.”

I don’t have a response to that. Or I have too many, and none of them are professional, so I say nothing.

He steps back into the main room, and the air between us expands again.

“The desk goes there,” he says. “Do it.”

We spend the next hour on the living room. I’ve brought fabric samples for the sofa — a bouclé in ivory, a raw silk in charcoal, a velvet in that dried-blood colour I mentioned. He touches each one. His hands are large, long-fingered, careful. He doesn’t grab or pinch. He presses his palm flat and lets the fabric speak.

“The velvet,” he says.

“You sure? It’s the most expensive.”

“I’m sure.”

I make a note. “I’ll have it made up. Low arms, deep seat. It faces the windows. In the afternoon the light comes through and turns the whole room amber. You’ll sit there and read and forget what time it is.”

“You’re selling it.”

“I’m describing it. There’s a difference.”

He looks at me. “You said that before. About the kitchen.”

“Because it’s true both times.”

He’s quiet for a moment. Then: “Eleanor told me she found your firm because of a project in Notting Hill. A Victorian terrace. She said the designer refused to use marble in

the bathroom because, and I quote, ‘the house didn’t deserve it.’ ”

“That was me.”

“Why did you refuse?”

“Because the house was built in 1872 and the owner wanted to turn it into a miniature Dubai. I told her if she wanted marble she should buy a new flat. She didn’t hire me. Someone else did it her way. I see the house sometimes when I walk past. It’s exactly as ugly as I predicted.”

He laughs. Actually laughs. It’s short, surprised, like he didn’t expect it to come out of him. The sound changes his face completely. He looks younger. Less careful.

“You don’t compromise,” he says.

“No.”

“That’s why I chose you. I looked at forty portfolios. Everyone else showed me beautiful rooms. You showed me rooms that made sense. There’s a difference.”

There’s that phrase again. The one I keep using. He’s noticed it too.

“I should go,” I say. “I’ll have the full concept to you by Friday. You can look it over, make notes, and we’ll meet again next week.”

“Maya.”

I stop. He’s used my first name. He hasn’t before.

“I don’t want you to just send the concept,” he says. “I want to go through it with you. Here. In person.”

“That’s not usually how it works.”

“I know. But I want to understand the thinking. Not just see the result.”

I should say no. I should keep the professional distance that’s kept me safe for eight years. But there’s something in the way he’s asking. Not demanding. Asking.

“Friday,” I say. “Four o’clock.”

“I’ll be here.”

I gather my samples. The limestone goes back into its case. The fabrics go into their protective sleeves. He watches me pack up with the same attention he gave the drawings.

At the door, I pause. “The plant in the study. Water it once a week. Not more. It dies from overwatering, not neglect.”

“I’ll remember.”

“And Dominic.”

“Yes?”

“The desk goes on Friday. I’ll have someone move it while I’m here. Don’t try to help.”

“I wouldn’t dream of it.”

The lift takes me down. In the lobby, I pass Eleanor, who’s arriving with a stack of folders. She nods at me. I nod back. We’ve never spoken beyond logistics, but there’s something in her expression that suggests she knows more than she should.

On the street, the afternoon has turned colder. I pull my coat tighter and walk toward the Tube. My phone buzzes. Freja.

“Well?”

“He approved everything.”

“And?”

“And nothing. It’s a job.”

“You’re a terrible liar. Even over text.”

I put the phone away. The truth is, I’m not lying. It is a job. It’s just that the job has started to feel like something else, and I don’t know what to do with that.

I think about his hands on the velvet. The way he said “clear-eyed” like it was a confession. The sound of his laugh,

unexpected and brief, like a door opening in a house he keeps locked.

I think about the desk in the study, facing the window, and how he'll sit there in the mornings and see the square and maybe think of me.

I descend into the Tube. The warmth of the underground hits me like a wall, and I stand on the platform waiting for the train, and I don't let myself think about Friday.

Chapter 3

Chapter 3

The finished flat is unrecognisable.

I stand in the doorway at six o'clock on a May evening, and the last light of the day comes through the tall windows and turns the Moleanos floors the colour of honey. The kitchen is open now, the wall I wanted gone, replaced by a single slab of limestone that flows from counter to island without a seam. The velvet sofa sits where I said it would, angled toward the windows, and the reading chair — upholstered in that deep burgundy velvet — waits beneath a warm brass lamp. Everything I drew six weeks ago is here. Everything I imagined is real.

But Dominic isn't in the living room. He's standing by the windows with his back to me, one hand resting on the glass, looking down at the square. The plane trees have leaves now, late spring green, and the evening light catches them and throws soft shadows across his shoulders.

"It's exactly what I wanted," he says without turning.

"You haven't seen the study yet."

"I don't mean the flat." He turns. He's wearing the same

navy suit from the first day, but no jacket. The white shirt is rolled at the forearms, and his tie is somewhere else, and there's something in his face that wasn't there six weeks ago. Or maybe it was always there and I'm only now allowing myself to see it.

I step inside. The door closes behind me with a soft click. The hush of the penthouse wraps around us — that particular silence of a high floor in Mayfair, where the city exists but can't reach you.

"I need to show you something," he says.

He walks toward me. Stops at a distance that's too close for professional and too far for anything else. I can smell the cedar again, and beneath it something warmer. Him, probably. Skin and clean cotton and the day.

"I looked at your portfolio again," he says. "Not the one on your website. The one you showed me that first day. The Notting Hill project. The Chelsea mews house. The studio in Shoreditch that you designed for yourself."

"Why?"

"Because I wanted to understand how your mind works. Every room you design has the same quality. You don't decorate. You find the thing the space wants to be, and you remove everything that gets in the way."

"That's what I do, yes."

"I've been thinking about that. About what I want. About what gets in the way." He pauses. His eyes don't leave mine. "I don't want to do this carefully. I don't want to pretend that I hired you for your limestone samples."

My breath catches. Just slightly. Just enough for him to notice.

"Dominic."

"I know. It's a complication. You're designing my flat.

There are professional boundaries. There are reasons this is a bad idea.” He doesn’t move closer. He just stands there, letting me see him clearly. “But I’m not going to pretend I don’t want you. Not tonight. Not in this room you built for me.”

The light shifts. A cloud passes over the square and the room dims and then brightens again, and I’m standing in the middle of a space I designed and I can feel every choice I made in it. The warmth of the stone under my feet. The texture of the air. The way the room holds sound.

“I’ve been hurt before,” I say. “By someone who wanted me smaller. Someone who loved the idea of me but not the reality of what I do.”

“I know. You told me.”

“And you’re still —”

“I’m still asking. I’m not assuming. I’m asking.”

I look at him. At the sharp cheekbones and the grey temples and the mouth that doesn’t waste words. At the man who replaced an orchid because I told him to. Who moved his desk because I said it would change his mornings. Who sat with a fabric sample in his hand and understood what I meant about rooms that make sense.

“If we do this,” I say, “it changes everything.”

“Yes.”

“And you’re comfortable with that.”

“No. I’m aware of it. There’s a difference.”

I almost laugh. I’ve used that same line. He’s giving it back to me.

I close the distance between us. I don’t touch him yet. I just stand close enough to feel the heat of him through my clothes. His hand comes up slowly, and he touches my jaw with his fingertips. Barely contact. Just enough to let me feel

the shape of it.

“Tell me what you want,” he says.

“I want you to stop being careful.”

His hand slides into my hair. His fingers press against the back of my head, and he tilts my face up, and his mouth finds mine. It’s not tentative. It’s not a question. His lips are warm and his hand is firm and when I open my mouth against his he makes a sound low in his throat that I feel in my chest.

I grab the front of his shirt. The cotton is soft under my fingers, and beneath it I can feel the heat of him, the solid reality of his body. He kisses me deeper, his tongue against mine, and I let myself stop thinking about what this means and just feel it.

He walks me backward. The backs of my legs hit the velvet sofa and I sit, and he follows me down, one hand on the arm, the other still in my hair. The velvet is soft behind my back. His weight presses me into it, and I can feel the length of him against my hip, hard, and it sends a pulse of heat through me.

“Come here,” I say against his mouth.

He pulls back just enough to look at me. His eyes are dark, pupils blown. “Are you sure?”

“I’ve been sure since you told me the Calacatta was cold.”

He laughs, that surprised sound I remember from the hallway. Then his mouth is on my neck, and I stop laughing, and my head tips back, and his lips trace the line from my jaw to my collarbone. His hand slides along my waist, fingertips catching on the silk of my blouse, and the texture of it — silk and his rough fingertips — makes me gasp.

He undoes the buttons slowly. One at a time. His mouth follows his fingers, kissing each new inch of skin. When the blouse falls open he pushes it off my shoulders and I’m sitting

there in my bra, plain black cotton, nothing designed about it, and he looks at me like I'm the most carefully constructed thing he's ever seen.

"You're beautiful," he says.

"Don't —"

"I know. Not a cliché. It's just true."

I pull him back down. His skin is warm when I slide my hands under his shirt, pushing it up and off. He helps me, pulling it over his head, and I run my palms across his chest. Lean muscle, a trail of dark hair below his navel. The shape of him is unexpected. He's built like someone who uses his body, not someone who shows it off.

We move together onto the sofa, a tangle of limbs and the soft crush of velvet. His mouth finds my breast, tongue circling my nipple through the cotton, and I arch into him. The sensation is sharp and sweet and I want more. I reach behind my back and unhook the bra, pull it away, and his mouth is there immediately, warm and wet, and I let myself make a sound I didn't know I was going to make.

"God," he says against my skin.

"Don't stop."

His hand slides down. Finds the waistband of my trousers, pauses. I nod. He undoes them and slides them down my hips, and I kick them off, and then I'm lying on the velvet sofa in nothing but my underwear, and he's looking at me with an expression I want to keep for the rest of my life.

"You designed this room," he says. "You told me the light would be amber in the evenings."

"It is."

"I've thought about you in this light every day for six weeks."

I reach for him. Pull him down. His weight is solid and

warm and right. We kiss again, slower now, deeper. His hand slides over my hip, fingers tracing the edge of my underwear, and I lift my hips to help him pull them off.

When we're both naked, he pauses. Looks at me. His hand rests on my stomach, thumb tracing slow circles on my skin.

"I want you to tell me if you want to stop," he says.

"I won't want to stop."

"But if I do something you don't like —"

"I'll tell you. I promise."

He kisses me again. Soft at first, then harder. His hand slides between my thighs and I let my legs fall open. His fingers find me, and the touch is careful, deliberate, exactly what I didn't know I needed. I make a sound against his mouth and he answers with a low hum of satisfaction.

He touches me until I'm shaking. Until my hand is gripping his shoulder and my hips are moving against his fingers and there's nothing in the world but the sound of my breathing and the feel of him and the amber light on the ceiling. When I come it's slow, rolling, a wave that builds and breaks and leaves me boneless beneath him.

"Look at me," he says.

I open my eyes. He's above me, his weight on his arms, watching my face.

"I want to be inside you," he says.

"Yes."

He reaches for his trousers on the floor, finds a wallet, a condom. I watch him put it on and then he's pressing against me, and I wrap my legs around his hips, and he slides in slowly.

The feeling is enormous. Full and warm and exactly right. He stills for a moment, his forehead pressed to mine, breath-

ing hard.

“Okay?” he asks.

“Yes. Move.”

He does. Slowly at first, long strokes that make me feel every inch of him. I run my hands down his back, feel the muscles shift under his skin. The rhythm builds. Faster. Harder. The sofa creaks beneath us and neither of us cares.

“Maya,” he says. Just my name. Nothing else.

I pull him closer. His pace quickens and I meet him, thrust for thrust, and the tension builds again, different this time, sharper. He slides his hand between us, finds me again, and I cry out.

“I’ve got you,” he says. “Let go.”

I do. I come with his name in my mouth, and he follows a moment later, his whole body going rigid, his face buried in my neck, and the sound he makes is the most honest thing I’ve ever heard him say.

We lie there for a long time. His weight on me, both of us breathing hard, the velvet damp beneath us. Outside, the square has gone dark. The room is lit only by the glow of the city below.

“I don’t want you to leave,” he says.

“I have to. Tomorrow.”

“I know. But I don’t want you to.”

I touch his hair. It’s damp at the temples. “Ask me again tomorrow.”

He lifts his head. Looks at me. “Will the answer be different?”

“No. But it’ll feel different to hear it.”

He rolls onto his side, pulls me against him. We fit together in the way that bodies do when they’ve figured out how to share a space. His arm around me. My head on his

chest. The velvet beneath us and the amber light fading to dark.

“The flat is perfect,” he says.

“You’re welcome.”

“I meant what I said. About the rooms that make sense.”

I press my lips to his shoulder. “So did I.”

We fall asleep there. On the sofa I designed, in the room he’s learning to live in, with the windows open to the Mayfair night and the sound of the city below and the smell of cedar and limestone and us.

In the morning I’ll call Freja. I’ll tell her she was right and she was wrong. I’ll tell her about the Calacatta and the limestone and the desk by the window and the way he said my name when he was inside me. I’ll tell her that I designed a room for a man and then let him design something in me.

But that’s morning. Right now there’s just this. The weight of his arm. The warmth of the velvet. The room I made that made this possible.

I close my eyes and sleep.
